

Let Big Brother watch – Part 2

Assuming you've already read Sidharth's column or last month's cover story, it will become obvious to you that we at Team Digit often disagree on many issues. At Digit, debate is always encouraged – especially when the topics are sensitive. For example, last month's Free Basics debate continues even today, much after the rest of the world stopped caring.

In January 2009, I wrote part 1 of this editorial (not knowing at the time that it was a part 1). It was in the aftermath of the 26/11 Mumbai Terror Attacks that was perpetrated by gun-toting cowards from Pakistan, and yes, I'll admit to being very angry when writing it. However, I don't think I've changed my mind, even after I've had time to think about it. I still believe that my personal privacy isn't more important than someone else's life.

I just cannot fathom what the average person has to hide. No one really cares if you're having an affair, sending naked pictures, surfing porn, pirating movies, hacking your neighbour's Wi-Fi... Sorry to burst another bubble, but no matter how important you think you are, you're a nobody in the grand scheme of things.

I also really don't get the indignation over the evil government agency reading my emails, hacking my phone, tracking my movements or any of that. In a First World country, people are always under surveillance. There are CCTVs everywhere – some government set-up and some privately owned – and everyone happily shares CCTV footage or information with the authorities in case of an accident or crime. Does this mean that there's more "privacy" for people in India from the government or law enforcement authorities, as opposed to, say, the US or Australia? Yes. Now ask yourself if that privacy has resulted in anything other than corruption, lawlessness and in some cases, mob justice.

In this whole Apple vs. FBI debate that's happening as I write this opinion piece, I don't trust Apple any more than I trust the FBI. I am a proud skeptic. Yes, Edward Snowden gave us a peek into the dark underbelly of certain government agencies, but are you really gullible enough to believe that it's any better within greedy corporate companies? Since we're so quick to accept conspiracy theories (especially when it involves a government), here are a few more:

Could this not be another publicity opportunity being exploited to the fullest by the world's second-most valuable company? Does it strike

no one else as just a tad fishy that this is happening immediately after Apple lost the top spot to Google (technically Alphabet)? Can you think of a better way of publicising the security of your products? Basically, Apple is telling the world that its products are so impenetrable that even the mighty US government cannot get into one. It's win-win: It gets to play the good guy, receive a pat on its back by all and sundry for standing up to the evil government, and forever put to bed the memories of its security lapses in the past. Plus, have you considered that this is also Tim Cook's moment in the sun, and an opportunity for someone other than the late Steve Jobs to be Apple's rock star?

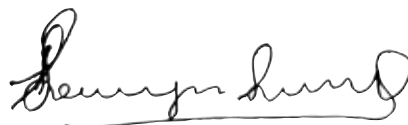
I don't know about you, but I'm not ready just yet to jump up and down, scream in joy and throw my undergarments at Tim Cook when he appears on a stage.

Is it possible that Apple is indeed standing up for what's right? Yes. And is it possible that the opposite is true? Yes, equally so. At least to me.

FBI Director, James Comey is certainly hinting at that. In a letter put out on February 21, 2016, Comey basically referred to Apple as a greedy corporation. You can read the full letter at: <http://1.usa.gov/1oCQnYU>

So, am I saying we should just let the FBI do whatever it pleases? Of course not. Everything needs checks and balances in place, including technology, and especially government agencies. However, I do think we need to grow up and realise that technology is just technology, but it can be used for both bad and good. Just as you may not want your competitors spying on your employees through backdoors built into Apple's technology, you don't want terrorists being able to use the same security to plan an attack that could kill your loved ones. There is no black or white in such situations – grey is where most of our lives are lived.

Also, remember, Apple and other technology companies are already monitoring your devices and your usage of their services like Big Brother. They're doing this in order to get you to spend more money, whilst the government's motive is to control you (and stop you from getting blown up now and then). Bottomline? You have no choice other than to let Big Brother watch... it's just a question of which Big Brother, and why. 




Robert Sovereign-Smith
Executive Editor
robert@digit.in

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